the fact that Humphrys had quickly developed a dislike for Amanullah on his arrival in Afghanistan. The British minister looked down upon the emir, and opposed the nationalist and modernising forces prevalent in Kabul in the post-war period.[179] Nonetheless, Anglo-Afghan relations had a history of these ups-and-downs, and the Indian government had become particularly adept at dealing with its neighbour's vacillations. Importantly, the Indian government was also able to recognise the old Afghan trick of trying to play Russia and Britain off against each other, and was sensible enough to refuse to become involved in the emir's Turkestan adventures. By 1923 then, Anglo-Afghan relations were in a relatively stable position. Just as the trade agreement with Russia did not preclude Britain experiencing irritations with that country, so too did India's relationship with Afghanistan continue to see its peaks and troughs even following the treaty of 1921. However, as with the Soviet trade agreement, the treaty with Afghanistan did bring a level of resolution to some of the issues between India and its neighbour, not least because it provided the Indian government with much needed clout. From 1921 Britain could always threaten to rescind the treaty and its concessions whenever Amanullah decided to become unreasonable.

Build, Build, Build

By the end of 1923 it appeared that Britain's foreign relations in South Asia had come full circle, almost to pre-First World War days. The ambitious optimism of the immediate post-war months had dissipated and the reality of the situation in the region had set in. Curzon's temerity had been replaced with the Indian government's sensibility and by 1923 Britain's standing had improved from the low to which it had sunk in 1920–1921. In Persia, Loraine's policy of detachedness proved effective damage control after the embarrassment of the failed Anglo-Persian Agreement and the Enzeli debacle. After months of failing to come to grips with the Turkish question, the settlement at Lausanne and the creation of the new Turkish Republic finally resolved many problems for Britain, not least of which was the settlement of the Caliphate issue. The removal of this cause célèbre simultaneously resulted in a cooling down of pan-Islamic agitation and a